

For laying out small posters or creating bookmarks and even adverts that spread the word about new books via social media, FOSS has some useful software to deal with vector graphics, like Inkscape. You can use it to create illustrations, diagrams, logos, and (if you have the skills) even complex paintings. Inkscape is a mature program that works with GNU/Linux, Windows and Mac. Using software such as this would save you a tidy sum, and keep your conscience clear about not using any 'pirated' products.

The GIMP (the GNU Image Manipulation Processor) is great for photo editing and as powerful as Photoshop. RAW photos can be converted to, say, JPG formats using the GIMP UFRaw plugin. Images can be converted to gray-scale, adjusted for full white and full black, and the GIMP can have their level curve adjusted for mid-tones. Then, before going in for printing, the saved press profile can be used for max white and max black percentages.

Don't forget that publishers need to type in large amounts of text, or at least work on what texts the authors have submitted. OpenOffice (or Apache OpenOffice) is one option. Like Word, you could run into problems if you try to edit a document of hundreds of pages in a single file in OpenOffice. You can't generate press-ready PDFs using a word processor, but on the plus side, OpenOffice can import "almost any word processor format ever invented." This is quite unlike Word.

If you're old-fashioned like me, and like pure computing power without too much fancy stuff, you could even use a simple text editor like Jstar or Joe (similar to the WordStar program that many in India used in the 1980s). I love this; it allows me to use both hands for typing, and I've never suffered from the RSI brought on by repeated mouse movements.

Scrivner is another useful tool, which comes with a Linux-compatible version too. It helps a writer to outline, storyboard, write and edit books, long reports, movie scripts, etc. Way back in 2011, Scrivner announced that it was offering a beta version for GNU/Linux. I have it installed but haven't got down to using it actively.

'Made-by-a-Mumbaikar' Calibre features on the top of many lists for ebook management software. Calibre helps you create your ebook without difficulty, and can generate a range of formats. For input files, it accepts DOCX, PDF, PRC, HTML, EPUB, PML, AZW, CBZ, AXW3, CBC and others. Output comes as MOBI, ZIP, DOCX, HTMLZ, AZW3, TXT and PDF, among others. Calibre works on GNU/Linux, Windows and iOS.

Sigil is yet another charming and ultra useful ebook creator. It lets you view the code along with regular and WYSIWYG views. Sigil also allows you to spellcheck, and create a contents table and a book browser.

Top FOSS tools for book publishing

- LyX: <http://www.lyx.org>
- Scribus: <https://www.scribus.net/>
- Inkscape: <https://inkscape.org/>
- GIMP: <http://www.gimp.org>
- Apache OpenOffice: <http://www.openoffice.org>
- Jstar
- Scrivner: <https://www.literatureandlatte.com/scrivener/overview>
- Calibre: <http://calibre-ebook.com>
- Sigil: <http://calibre-ebook.com>
- To create ebooks: Writer2ePub plugin

There are more options too. Opensource.com [<https://opensource.com/life/13/8/how-create-ebook-open-source-way>] has a nice article on how to create ebooks in the epub (open standard) format by using the LibreOffice Writer word processor, the Writer2ePub plugin for LibreOffice and an epub reader. It's that simple.

But take care of a few tips and tricks. In LibreOffice, press F11 to toggle the *Styles* and *Formatting* panes. Use styles (not font sizes) in your document. You need to use Headings, Body Text, Monospace text (for computer code, for example), and Extended quotations (for block quotes). Don't leave any text in your file unstructured.

Edit your content carefully, and avoid invisible, non-printing characters (use Ctrl+F10 to make these visible). Remove all such unnecessary characters. The Writer2ePub makes creating an epub file very easy. Before doing so, add the ebook's metadata (author's name, book title, book language, at least). A neat book cover can also be added. You can read your ebook in any epub reader.

Quite a few other useful FOSS tools help publishers in their work and make books more reasonably priced — as they should be. There is scanning software, software to control your printer and camera, and a few thousands more that help general computing work.

There are many other free-to-use but not free software products too, which could help anyone in this field, such as Google Docs, the online word processor; and Evernote for note-taking. Then there are quite a few free-of-cost word processors, style and grammar checkers, online document sharing platforms, or tools like WeTransfer that helps me exchange large files with my artist colleagues and printers. But again, don't confuse free software with free-of-cost software. **END** 

 By Frederick Noronha

The author, who is based in Goa, is a freelance journalist, a book publisher, and a strong proponent of FOSS. You can reach him at fredericknoronha2@gmail.com.